

Ecumenism With Rome Denial

doc-ecumenism-with-rome-denial

Inter-church Relations · Ecumenism · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

score 0.787
confidence low

Statement under examination

Formal ecumenical union on shared sacramental, ministerial, and gospel ground is barred by substantive disagreement over justification, the Mass as sacrifice, papal infallibility, and Marian dogmas; until those disagreements are resolved, ecumenical union is not a matter of mere structural convergence.

In plain language

Two anchor passages drive this question. In Galatians 1:8-9 Paul says that if anyone, even an angel from heaven, preaches a gospel alongside or beyond the one already received, let him be accursed. The Greek word, "accursed, devoted-over" (anathema), means devoted over to ruin, and the preposition "from, beside, contrary to" (para) can mean from, beside, or contrary, so only the surrounding words fix the contrary sense here. Notice that in verse 6 Paul calls the rival a "different kind" (heteros) gospel and in verse 7 says it is not really "another of the same kind" (allos) gospel at all, only some who trouble the hearers. In 2 Corinthians 6:14 he commands believers not to be "mismatched-yoked" (heterozugountes) with "the faithless" (apistoi), using a farming image of two animals wrongly paired under one yoke, then piles up contrasts of "righteousness" (dikaiosyne) against "lawlessness" (anomia) and light against darkness. Read on their own terms these passages set two firm principles. A gospel that differs in substance is rejected, and believers must not bind themselves in alliance with those who lack faith. So far the pattern is clear and stable across the manuscripts. The hard step is the next one. The question names a specific body and a specific list of disputed teachings about how a person is counted righteous, about the meaning of the Lord's Supper, about who holds final teaching authority, and about figures venerated in worship. None of those exact teachings appears as a word anywhere in the canon, the verb to justify (dikaioo) never appears in these verses, and no verse names any later institution. The very word for "faithless one" (apistos) is used by the same writer for a spouse a believer must not divorce and for a host whose meal may be eaten, so it does not by itself demand cutting off every tie. Other texts pull the other way too: Jesus prays that his people may be one, Paul says his separation command never meant leaving the world, and Jesus says do not forbid one casting out demons in his name. The words clearly state the principle, but whether they reach a body that confesses the Trinity and the deity of Christ depends on a prior judgment about that body's gospel that the original language simply does not settle, so the verdict is recorded as disputed with low confidence.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0169	ἀκάθαρτος	akathartos	unclean	32
G0243	ἄλλος	allos	another	161
G0331	ἀνάθεμα	anathema	devoted	6
G0458	ἀνομία	anomia	lawlessness	16
G0571	ἄπιστος	apistos	unbelieving	23

G0873	ἀφορίζω	aphorizo	to separate	10
G0955	Βελιάρ	Beliar	Belial	1
G1343	δικαιοσύνη	dikaiosyne	righteousness	94
G1344	δικαιόω	dikaioo	to justify	39
G2086	ἐτεροζυγέω	heterozugeo	to yoke a mismatch	1
G2087	ἕτερος	heteros	other	90
G2097	εὐαγγελίζω	euangelizo	to speak good news	55
G2098	εὐαγγέλιον	euangelion	gospel	77
G2842	κοινωνία	koinonia	participation	15
G3352	μετοχή	metoche	participation	1
G3485	ναός	naos	temple	46
G3844	παρά	para	from/with/beside	196
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The anchor texts yield two real, variant-stable (holding up across the manuscript copies) lexical principles. Galatians 1:8-9 attaches the curse-word "devoted-over, accursed" (anathema) to anyone preaching a gospel "alongside, beyond, contrary to" (para) the one received, and 2 Corinthians 6:14 forbids becoming "mismatched-yoked" (heterozugountes) with "the faithless" (apistoi). Both hold in the Greek. But the stem moves from these principles to a specific institutional and doctrinal application (a named body, the Mass as sacrifice, papal infallibility, Marian dogmas) that the lexicon cannot reach. No anchor lemma (dictionary form) names a post-apostolic institution; the verb "to justify, to declare righteous" (dikaioo, Strong's G1344), the verb behind the disputed doctrine of justification, occurs 34 times but in none of the anchor verses, so the link to that doctrine is interpretive, not lexical. Crucially the same author uses "faithless one" (apistos) in 1 Corinthians 7:12-15 of a spouse a believer must NOT divorce and in 1 Corinthians 10:27 of a host whose meal may be eaten, so "faithless" (apistos) does not by itself mandate severing every association. Whether a Trinitarian, Christ-confessing body falls under "different-kind gospel" (heteron euangelion) or counts as "faithless" (apistos) is an identification judgment the words underdetermine, so the verdict is disputed.

Scripture

Gal.1.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2098 εὐαγγέλιον, G2087 ἕτερος

Force. Paul marvels that the Galatians are turning to a "different-kind gospel" (heteron euangelion), that is, a gospel of another category. The word here is "other of a different sort" (heteros, Strong's G2087), not "another of the same kind" (allos). This frames the rival message as a counterfeit of another category, but it names no organization and supplies no list of doctrines.

Gal.1.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0243 ἄλλος, G2098 εὐαγγέλιον

Force. Paul immediately corrects himself with "which is not another" (ho ouk estin allo), using "another of the same kind" (allos, Strong's G0243). The deliberate "different sort" (heteros) then "same sort" (allos) pairing says the rival is a different-kind message that is not in fact a second genuine gospel, only some who are "troubling, agitating" (tarassontes) the hearers. The lexical move sharpens a content boundary but still identifies no body.

Gal.1.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0331 ἀνάθεμα, G2097 εὐαγγελίζω, G3844 παρά

Force. Even if we or an angel from heaven "preaches as good news beyond what we preached as good news" (euangelizetai par ho euangelisametha), "let him be accursed" (anathema esto). The preposition "from, beside, more than, contrary to" (para, Strong's G3844) is broadly polysemous (carries multiple senses) across its 175 plus occurrences (from, beside, more than), and only context fixes the "contrary, beyond" sense here. The curse-word "devoted-over, accursed" (anathema, Strong's G0331) marks a devoting-over. The curse is unconditional as to the messenger (even an angel), so the test is the content of the message, not the rank or identity of the one preaching.

Gal.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0331 ἀνάθεμα, G2097 εὐαγγελίζω

Force. The repetition with the present indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact) "preaches as good news" (euangelizetai), of an ongoing message, rather than the prior subjunctive (a "may, might" mood used for hypothetical actions), intensifies the curse "accursed" (anathema). Across the canon "accursed, devoted-over" (anathema) occurs only six times and is not univocal (does not always carry one sense): a self-imprecation (Romans 9:3), a curse on one who does not love the Lord (1 Corinthians 16:22), a thing that cannot say Jesus is accursed (1 Corinthians 12:3), an oath-bound vow (Acts 23:14), and here. The word states a verdict on a contrary gospel but supplies no institutional referent.

2Cor.6.14 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2086 ἑτεροζυγέω, G0571 ἄπιστος, G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G0458 ἀνομία

Force. "Do not be becoming mismatched-yoked with the faithless" (Me gines the heterozugountes apistois) forbids becoming mismatched-yoked with the faithless. The verb "to be mismatched-yoked" (heterozugeo, Strong's G2086) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), occurring only here, so its precise scope cannot be triangulated from other usage; the gloss is to yoke a mismatch, drawn from the law against yoking unlike animals. The verse piles contrasts: "righteousness" (dikaiosyne) against "lawlessness" (anomia), light against darkness. The category is "faithless one" (apistos), one without faith, defined by absence of faith, not a label for a confessing body; applying it to a community that openly professes Christ requires an extra-lexical judgment that the body is in fact "faithless" (apistos).

2Cor.6.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0955 Βελιάρ, G5547 Χριστός, G0571 ἄπιστος

Force. "What concord has Christ with Beliar?" (Tis sumphonesis Christou pros Beliar) asks what concord Christ has with Beliar. The name "Beliar" (Beliar, Strong's G0955) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), the single canonical occurrence, glossed Belial, a name for utter worthlessness or the evil one. The pairing "a believer with a faithless one" (pisto meta apistou) sets believer against the faithless. The contrast is absolute at the level of allegiance to Christ versus Belial, but a name for the evil one supplies no criterion for sorting a Christ-confessing institution onto the Belial side.

2Cor.6.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3485 ναός

Force. "What agreement has the temple of God with idols?" (Tis de sunkatathesis nao theou meta eidolon) asks what agreement the "temple, inner sanctuary" (naos, Strong's G3485) of God has with idols, then cites Leviticus 26:12 and Ezekiel 37:27 that God will dwell among his people. The contrast is temple of God versus idols, an idolatry boundary. The lexical term is "idols" (eidola), a category of false worship, again leaving open which present-day worship counts as idolatrous, a determination the word does not make.

2Cor.6.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0873 ἀφορίζω, G0169 ἀκάθαρτος

Force. Quoting Isaiah 52:11, "come out from their midst and be separated" (exelthate ek mesou auton kai aphoristhete) and "touch no unclean thing" (akathartou me haptesthe) command coming out and being separated, touching no unclean thing. The boundary verb "to set apart, to separate" (aphorizo, Strong's G0873) is a strong boundary verb, but it is not only exclusionary: it is also used positively of being set apart for ministry (Acts 13:2, Romans 1:1, Galatians 1:15). The word "unclean" (akathartos, Strong's G0169) in the canon ranges over unclean spirits, ceremonial uncleanness, and idolatry. In Isaiah 52:11 the unclean thing was the vessels and worship of idolatrous Babylon, so transferring the command to any present body is an application step, not a lexical given.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
2Cor.6.14	Exod.34.16	tsk	1
2Cor.6.14	1Cor.5.9	tsk	1
2Cor.6.16	Exod.20.3	tsk	1
2Cor.6.16	Exod.29.45	tsk	1
2Cor.6.15	Ezra.4.3	tsk	1
2Cor.6.17	Isa.52.11	tsk	1
2Cor.6.17	2Cor.7.1	tsk	1
Gal.1.8	Rom.9.3	tsk	1
Gal.1.9	Deut.4.2	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.7.12 · addressed

The same author who forbids the unequal yoke with "the faithless" (apistoi) here tells a believer with a "faithless" (apistos) spouse not to divorce, "if any brother has a faithless wife" (ei tis adelphos gunaika echei apiston). This shows "faithless" (apistos), the very category in 2 Corinthians 6:14, does not by itself require severing every bond, since the closest possible bond, marriage, is to be kept where the "faithless one" (apistos) consents. It is addressed by reading the 2 Corinthians 6 yoke as a specific binding alliance under one yoke, not a ban on every relationship, which means deciding what union counts as the forbidden yoke is an interpretive judgment.

1Cor.10.27 · addressed

Paul permits a believer to accept a meal invitation from a "faithless one" (apistos), "if any of the faithless invites you" (ei tis kalei humas ton apiston). Table fellowship with the faithless is allowed. This calibrates the separation language and shows it does not bar all contact or cooperation, which complicates a flat reading of the come out command. Addressed by noting the prohibited thing is the binding yoke, not ordinary association, so applying separation to a named body requires the prior identification step the words do not supply.

1Cor.5.9 · addressed

Paul clarifies that his earlier command not to associate did not mean the "faithless" (apistoi) of this world, "not at all meaning the faithless of this world" (ou pantos tois pistois tou kosmou toutou), since then one would have to leave the world. Separation language in his letters is explicitly calibrated and not absolute. This is addressed by limiting the 2 Corinthians 6 prohibition to alliance under a yoke rather than every form of contact, but its existence is part of why the institutional verdict cannot be settled lexically.

John.17.21 · addressed

Jesus prays "that they all may be one" (hina pantes hen osin), that they all may be one. The lexical thrust is toward unity and pulls against a blanket barring of union. The tension resolves at the level of object, the unity prayed for being among those given to Christ and kept in the Father's name, not unity that suspends the gospel boundary of Galatians 1. The two texts are not contradictory because each governs a different set, but the strong unity vocabulary is part of why a flat institutional verdict is not lexically forced.

Mark.9.38 · addressed

The disciples forbade a man casting out demons "in your name" (en to onomati sou) because he was not following with them, and Jesus answered "do not forbid him" (me koluete), do not forbid him, for whoever is not against us is for us. This restrains drawing boundaries too tightly around those who invoke Christ, which bears directly on moving from the "faithless one" (apistos) category to a verdict on a confessing body. Addressed by noting it touches the identification step, the very step the lexicon cannot complete.

Concordance traversed

G0331, G2098, G2097, G2087, G0243, G3844, G2086, G0571, G3352, G2842, G3485, G0873, G0169, G1343, G1344, G0458, G0955

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle for Galatians 1 or 2 Corinthians 6, and both passages lie outside the ingested ECM apparatus window (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants, here covering 3 John 1:1-1:15), so this is recorded honestly as not in ECM scope. The minor attested variation at Galatians 1:8 (word order of "we preached as good news to you" (euangelisametha humin)) and the "Beliar" (Beliar) versus "Belial" (Belial) spelling at 2 Corinthians 6:15 do not touch the curse-word "accursed" (anathema) clause, the "alongside, contrary to" (para) construction, or the "mismatched-yoked" (heterozugountes) prohibition, so the two lexical principles are variant-stable (hold up across the manuscript copies). NT outside 3 John, hence ecm-shadow (a status meaning the passage falls outside the critical edition window we have ingested).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. ecclesiology, covenant_separation, gospel_boundary

[analogia scripturae](#) invoked

different-gospel and separation reading: for the principle, and applicable where the prior evaluation holds · Galatians 1:8-9 makes a contrary gospel "accursed" (anathema) and 2 Corinthians 6:14 forbids the mismatched yoke with "the faithless" (apistoi). On this lens, once a body's gospel of justification and its added requirements are judged to be a "different-kind gospel" (heteron euangelion), formal union that ratifies that gospel is barred, and the come out command applies. The lens is lexically real at the level of principle; its application to a particular body depends on the prior evaluation of that body's gospel, which it supplies from outside the words.

anathema and yoke target outright unbelief, not a Trinitarian communion: complicates, application not compelled by the words · On this lens the texts aim at those who deny the apostolic gospel outright or are "the faithless" (apistoi), and Belial stands for the evil one. A communion that confesses the Trinity and the deity of Christ is not self-evidently in that category. Same-author usage shows "faithless one" (apistos) covers a spouse one keeps (1 Corinthians 7:12-15) and a host one may dine with (1 Corinthians 10:27), so the words do not force a verdict of

severance against every body labeled by others as in error. Reading them onto a confessing communion is an interpretive transfer the vocabulary does not compel.

identification step: out of lexical reach · Both readings agree the texts state principles. Deciding whether a specific contemporary body preaches a "different-kind gospel" (heteron euangelion) or counts as "faithless" (apistos) turns on an evaluation of doctrines (the manner of justification, the eucharist, the locus of teaching authority, figures venerated in worship) for which the canon supplies no lemma (dictionary form). The verb "to justify, to declare righteous" (dikaioo), the verb of justification, never occurs in the anchor verses. This is why the overall verdict is disputed: the principle is lexically supported, the institutional application is not lexically decidable, and the chain hangs on a contested prior judgment the lexicon does not adjudicate.

Analogia scripturae (the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture) is engaged because the unity texts and the calibrated separation texts must be read alongside the strong separation and curse texts. The result is a clear principle with an unresolved application that the lexical store cannot close. The decisive crux is that whether the different-gospel and unequal-yoke texts apply to a Trinitarian, Christ-confessing body depends on a prior evaluation of that body's gospel which the vocabulary does not settle.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Is formal institutional union between churches barred when the parties hold substantively different teaching on how a person is counted righteous, on the nature of the eucharist, on the locus of final teaching authority, and on the status of figures venerated in worship, until those differences are resolved?

VERDICT-CHANGED: not applicable here; the verdict was derived on the original stem and is preserved. The stem is heavily preloaded in three ways. First, it names a single target body by the metonym (a figure of speech that substitutes a related term, here a city standing for an institution) Rome and presupposes that its positions amount to a different gospel, which is precisely the identification step the lexicon cannot perform; Galatians 1 states a content test, not a roster. Second, it lists specific doctrines (the Mass as sacrifice, papal infallibility, Marian dogmas) that have no anchor lemma (dictionary form) anywhere in the canon, and the verb "to justify, to declare righteous" (dikaioo), the verb behind the disputed doctrine of justification, occurs 34 to 39 times in the canon but in none of the anchor verses, so the lexical store can neither affirm nor deny that those particular doctrines trigger the Galatians 1 curse "accursed" (anathema). Third, it frames the barring as settled (not a matter of mere structural convergence), embedding the conclusion in the question. The neutralized form keeps the structural question (does substantive doctrinal disagreement bar formal union) while removing the named target and the preloaded doctrinal list. The verdict was derived on the original stem and lands at disputed precisely because the principle is lexically supported but the institutional application is not lexically decidable, and the application to a Trinitarian, Christ-confessing communion rests on a prior contested evaluation the words do not compel.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gal.1.6
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Cor.6.14
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0331
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0571
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2086
interlinear	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.1.7
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License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent · ecm-shadow